to turn them around. He had not, and subsequent clashes between US ASW forces and the Project 641s led to some of the most dangerous moments of the crisis. Other ships carrying vital military material did turn around, reflecting Moscow's determination that highly sensitive equipment should not fall into US hands. This included the twenty-four R-14 IRBMs.

On Cuba, Soviet troops hastened to bring their thirty-six R-12 MRBMs to a state of operational readiness. Soviet troops were also equipped with some one hundred tactical nuclear weapons: cruise missiles, short-range rockets, and nuclear bombers. These tactical nuclear weapons were to repel a US invasion of Cuba, should the MRBMs not deter them. The commander of Soviet forces in Cuba, General Issa Pliyev, was originally to be given authority to use tactical nuclear weapons if communication with Moscow failed during a US invasion.

Most nuclear ordnance was held in storage bunkers, though sixty-eight warheads remained aboard the *Aleksandrovsk* in La Isabela harbour (including twenty-four megaton-yield devices intended for the R-14 IRBMs). The R-12s had arrived by mid-September on board the freighters *Omsk* and *Poltava*. Their warheads were hidden fifty miles away at an underground bunker near Bejucal, though there are contested claims that on Saturday, 27 October, warheads arrived at MRBM launch sites.[45] There is no suggestion that warheads were mated to missiles (in contrast to western IRBMs in Britain, Italy, and Turkey).

What of Soviet strategic nuclear weapons? It has been argued that Moscow took only limited measures in response to changes in the US DEFCON states, out of fear of provoking a US attack.[46] Most recently, Theodore Voorhees contends the Soviets did not alert their nuclear forces and he draws from this the conclusion that Khrushchev would not have used nuclear weapons (because he knew he would lose a nuclear war).[47]

A history of the US National Security Agency, declassified in 2008, revealed that Soviet forces did adopt unprecedented high alert states on three occasions during September and October 1962.[48] After Kennedy's speech on 22 October, Soviet forces went on an 'extraordinarily high state of alert' with the emphasis on air defence forces, although 'offensive forces